RESTORATION DRAMA

ART

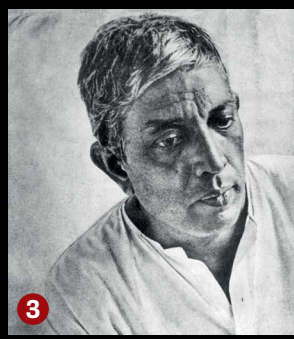
Artist **Jamini Roy's** house in Kolkata is being converted into an art gallery dedicated to his works

AN ARTIST'S ABODE
(1) Jamini Roy's house; (2) design by Roy and his son Amiya; (3) a photo of Roy; (4) a corridor connecting two apartments; (5) a window designed by Roy

Photographs COURTESY: DAG


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IT IS AN APRIL AFTERNOON. INSIDE THE SPACIOUS, SILENT ROOMS of a recently vacated, three-storey house in the quiet Kolkata neighbourhood of Ballygunge Place, sunlight reflects off the glass panes of foliage-covered windows, flooding floors with green and gold light. Though empty, the walls still seem to echo with the whispers and voices of the hundreds of people who had once dropped in. "Not a day went by when visitors didn't throng these premises, decades ago," sighs Amitava Kahali, 65, who lives just opposite and remembers sighting, on a daily basis, a string of celebrities from his balcony.

The vacant house, now a decaying testimony to times gone by, belonged to Jamini Roy, the internationally acclaimed artist who, in the early twentieth century, pioneered a movement in art, which for the first time, depicted themes